Speech at Wheeling, West Virginia

Senator Joseph R. McCarthy · February 9, 1950

Source: Joseph R. McCarthy, "Enemies from Within," Wheeling, W.Va. (1950). Public domain. Continuous passage.

> McCarthy's claim to hold a list of Communists in the State Department launched the anticommunist "Red Scare" of the 1950s. No complete transcript survives; this is the text McCarthy later placed in the record. (He said "57" here; newspapers reported "205.")

Today we are engaged in a final, all-out battle between communistic atheism and Christianity. The modern champions of communism have selected this as the time. And, ladies and gentlemen, the chips are down — they are truly down. . . . As one of our outstanding historical figures once said, "When a great democracy is destroyed, it will not be because of enemies from without, but rather because of enemies from within."

[. . .]

This is glaringly true in the State Department. There the bright young men who are born with silver spoons in their mouths are the ones who have been the worst. . . . In my opinion the State Department, which is one of the most important government departments, is thoroughly infested with Communists. I have in my hand 57 cases of individuals who would appear to be either card carrying members or certainly loyal to the Communist Party, but who nevertheless are still helping to shape our foreign policy. . . .